

FOMO

ANGRY FUN

An interview
with pop-punk
band lacocat

"RIOT-TWEE"

Legendary 90s band
Heavenly returns with
a new album after a 30-
year hiatus



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Heavenly returns with a new album after a 30 year hiatus.





LETTER FROM THE EDITOR

Music and memory are unmistakably tied together. No matter how grown I get, whenever I hear The Kinks croon about a well-respected man I think about the smell of my Dad's old Skoda Fabia. I'm sure you have a song that similarly transports you to a different time, a different place— memories of the exact life stage you were at are at the forefront of your mind whenever you listen to it.

Musicians feel the same way about the art they create. Nothing exists in a vacuum. Everything that they produce is a deeply personal product of their surroundings. The cities they live in, their community with other musicians, political movements, and their life experience all influence the kind of music they create. In this issue of FOMO, we highlight two bands that are prime examples of how situated in time music can be.

Tacocat, a pop-punk band based in Seattle, started out slightly unserious. Their first album, NVM, is ripe with songs about aliens and cat magazines. Despite the continuing love from fans for that phase, the band seems to look back on that music and almost cringe. To them, the relative optimism feels reserved for a simpler time. Their newer albums are more

serious, reflecting a changing culture and attitudes towards political issues. Heavenly, a British indie-pop band active the 90s, reflect on this phenomenon in their interview. Back after a 30-year hiatus, it's easy for them to have a birds-eye view of the phases they went through when they were active. Frontwoman Amelia Fletcher states that she has no regrets about the music she created. In fact, she is surprised by how good some of it was. But she can see herself grow up through these albums, from romantic and excited young woman to more experimental and aggressive with her sound.

With both bands releasing new albums after a longer period of time, it is interesting to consider how their sound will change based on their current environment and experience. Balancing the expectations of fans with a need to change their craft is a fine line to walk for musicians. Sometimes, a new direction doesn't land the way they would hope. But other times, it can

Risha Thimmancherla

Editor-in-Chief

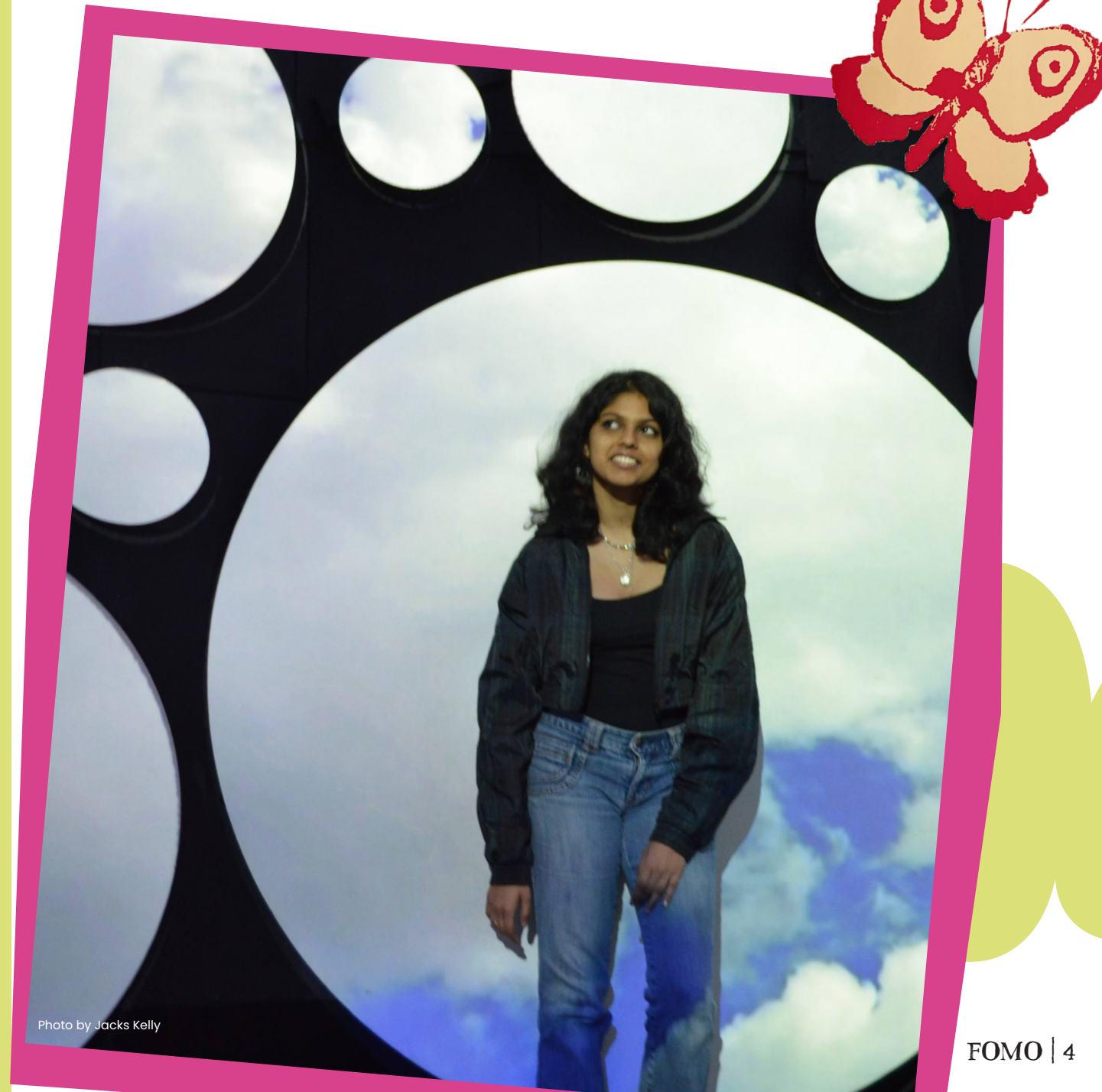


Photo by Jacks Kelly

ANGRY

An interview with Tacocat

by John Freeman (The Quietus)

FUN



So, let's go back a little. How did you guys initially meet and what were those first few weeks like as a band?

EN: We all met when we were really young. Eric [Randall], who plays guitar, was the only person who had been in a band previously. The rest of us were learning: Lelah [Maupin] was learning how to drum, Bree [McKenna] was learning how to play bass and we were really, really sloppy. I was just yelling, or maybe singing-yelling.

Did you have a vision for Tacocat? What 'gap' in the musical firmament were you trying to fill?

EN: There was no real vision. We were just trying to have a fun band that would play parties and have an excuse to go to crappy bars. At the time in Seattle, there were a lot of sombre dudes playing guitar music. We wanted to go back to a time when, for example, Beat Happening started and you didn't have to be super good, you just had to do it. In addition, we were very influenced by riot grrrl and we liked Jonathan Richman for not being overly serious.

Lost Time is your third album. Looking back, how has the Tacocat sound evolved?

EN: Our earliest phase now sounds to me almost like kids' music. Bree told me the other day that her favourite band was currently 'old' Tacocat. I thought it was too embarrassing to listen to, but I went back and played some stuff and the songs were so simple and funny. We didn't aspire to sound like anything – it was more about playing to our ability level at the time. We would write songs about Anna Nicole Smith or candy – and it was just as good as we could do. A lot of our music comes from conversations. Lost Time has a much more serious side to it, which is how things feel right now. So, we are more inspired by what is happening around us than any specific music style.

How have you developed as a lyricist?

EN: I used to write the lyrics to be able to shout in our standard punk songs. Then I learned how to sing, which meant we had more opportunity to weave melody into the songs and the lyrical aspect developed from that. When we started, it was just about, "What rhymes?" and now things are a little more advanced and complex.

"A lot of our
music comes from
conversations"



Photo from Subpop

Earlier this year, on a slate grey Sunday afternoon, I found myself in a church in Salford. This is an unusual occurrence. Suddenly, at their allotted hour, four people leap on to the small stage that is temporarily blocking out the altar, dressed head-to-toe in skeleton costumes and sporting various shocks of lime green and electric blue hair. They proceed to play 30 minutes of the most joyous punk-pop – songs seemingly about menstruation, hating the weekend, loving Seattle and mansplaining – and I feel my heart swell. I have just entered the world of Tacocat. On a Sunday afternoon. In a church.

And, the Tacocat world is a glorious place – the four-piece, hailing from the aforementioned US city and formed in 2007, are one of those gangs that make the lay punter long to join. It's a riot of colour, fun, wit, noisy melody and a withering disdain for a world of misogyny. It all makes me want to be in Tacocat – although I doubt they would want to accommodate a grumpy 46-year-old with a fixed early-to-bed routine.

Therefore, several weeks after the Salford church baptism, I have to make do with a Skype video chat with lead singer, Emily Nokes. She introduces me to her cat (I assume she likes tacos as well, and palindromes, but I don't ask). The cat is called Dr O (after a Roky Erickson

song, 'Bloody Hammer') and is huge (or maybe Emily is tiny). Unnervingly, Dr O flicks his tail menacingly throughout the interview as my questions become increasingly lame.

We are discussing Lost Time, Tacocat's third – and brilliant – album. Building on the bubblegum rock of 2014's NVM, and produced by Erik Blood, Lost Time is unselfconsciously bold and stuffed with pop hooks the size of Holland. It's a party record with an underlying agenda that has the band's burgeoning songcraft happily setting tracks about The X Files and high-school horse girls with Nokes' laser-guided dissection of internet trolls, the gentrification of Seattle and sexual politics side by side.

Nokes talks about the bond between the band members: "We have been best friends for as long as we have been in the band – I cannot imagine being in a band and hating each other like Metallica."

I cannot imagine anyone hating anything to do with Tacocat. Lost Time is their time – starting now.

I love that many of your songs address serious issues, but are presented in a fun and humorous way. Why do you take this approach and is there any danger that the power of the message could be lost?

EN: I think, from the beginning, we felt we had to make it funny, because that's the way we talk and what our sense of humour is like. However, we are making fun of issues through deep frustration, be it with masculinity, misogyny or the patriarchy. That stuff is so old and so ridiculous that it seems more appropriate to make fun of it than be super angry. Many women are so angry. Their anger is almost on a loop and is never going to disappear. Also, it's an anger cycle – and when you project anger at these people, they just project it back. However, there is something powerful about making fun of certain things. By making fun, you can crush people's ideals and take back some control. So, it didn't feel right to make that many angry songs. Any angry songs we tried to make just sounded like a different kind of music. It was hardcore, which is not what we are. It became important to make our point that way, as it was reaching people in a way that, perhaps, anger hadn't been reaching people.

However, I never want to make it seem that anger is 'over'. Deep down this all still does come from anger. Even the satire at the sheer ridiculousness of some of the issues has to come from a certain amount of rage. I still think it is really important to be angry. For some feminists or LGBT folk, that's all they have – sheer anger. Whereas I

“We are making fun of issues through deep frustration, be it with masculinity, misogyny or the patriarchy”

cannot do that in my art, I never want to make it seem that I don't appreciate that anger. Some people are better at it – we play with some bands that have an angry energy and it is awesome. Although, I don't necessarily want to see that from five white dudes being all 'woe is me' in a hardcore punk band.

As Tacocat's fanbase has grown, have you become more aware of the impact of your lyrics and does that affect what you write?

EN: I think it does a little bit. When we discovered that people were listening to us at all, and knew all the words to the songs, it did affect me. While there are a vast number of issues to be written about – especially about intersectional feminism – that I cannot quite speak to, it does still weigh on me that people will hear my words. Many of the songs come from conversations with my female friends. I used to think it was just me being cranky about certain situations, but the more



Photo from Subpop

I talked to other women, I realised it was a common annoyance. Therefore, a lot of the songs come through realising these are shared experiences, whereas before I would write a song because I like candy or cats or pizza.

The subject matters of your songs tend to be very specific. I love the clarity of your communication. Is there any downside to being so transparent in your lyric writing?

EN: Yes, definitely. The only way to make any real money is if a car commercial or a video

One of my favourite songs on Lost Time is the glorious 'I Hate The Weekend'. What made you dislike Saturdays and Sundays so much?

EN: The songs refers to how our neighbourhood in Seattle has changed so much. There are condos everywhere and all these awful, awful entitled rich people. They get so drunk and they are so disrespectful. They tip horribly and are always puking in sinks. They are worse than any of the punk gutter rats that we know. They are the worst behaved people in the neighbourhood and then they get to go back to work on a Monday. It doesn't matter to them; they are not invested in our area at all. That song is about that '80s mentality of 'working off the weekend', which is that capitalist bullshit of working 9-to-5 and then having a two-day permit from your job to run wild. We decided to do an anti-weekend anthem. In addition, our rent is going up – \$200 per month – so we have nowhere to live and nowhere to play. It's all shitty – but that's how it is everywhere.

Finally, what might album number four sound like?

EN: Well, there are a lot of different factors that might affect the next record. With NVM, we were still in a good mood and it was happy pop music. With Lost Time, the mood reflects the change in culture and the environment we are living in. Therefore, when we get down to writing the next album, it could well be very angry.

“With Lost Time, the mood reflects the change in culture and the environment we are living in.”

game want to use your song. However, nobody wants songs about periods. Sometimes we are told that we should have songs that were a little less obvious, but it is difficult for us to even think about how that might work. I cannot think how we would write something vague or abstract. So maybe that is the downside of being very overt in our lyrics.

ALBUM REVIEW

Tacocat's This Mess Is a Place

by Sophie Kemp (Pitchfork)

When Tacocat first entered indie rock's collective consciousness, "pastel goth" and flasks laminated in Lisa Frank stickers were very cool, and "resting bitch face" had yet to become a pop-feminism cliché. The Seattle-based four-piece came up in perhaps the simpler times of the early 2010s. Consistent but not exactly prolific, Tacocat could've easily fallen into the trap of sounding like any other unabashedly twee group that ripened in the first half of the decade. Thankfully, *This Mess Is a Place*, the group's fourth record and their first for Sub Pop, is a forward-thinking pop-punk that successfully—albeit narrowly—manages to dodge the obvious pitfalls.

On *This Mess Is a Place*, Tacocat play with a familiar set of girl-group and grunge-rock influences, adding inklings of straight-up pop. Album opener "Hologram" is a sort of Dressy Bessy meets the Marine Girls situation, with goopy, multi-part harmonies and saccharine guitars. The song asks the big questions in life: "How did we come to be so jaded?" and, "Is numb even a feeling?" Instead of answering these profundities with equally anesthetized sonics, the band's pure indie bubblegum does the exact opposite. If Tacocat feel life is stagnant and stale, their own art might be the antidote.

Tacocat have always encapsulated the kind of cheerfully campy aesthetic that encourages "shoveling yourself out of the shit" on bad days. They make fun music in a time when goofing off seems

almost antediluvian, and being earnest is worse. On "New World," a song as sugary as shotgunned Mountain Dew, Tacocat ask listeners to imagine waking up to beauty, rather than dread. Life might suck, lead vocalist Emily Nokes seems to say, but what if for one day it didn't? "I woke up today/And all my friends were happy/No one to tell them when to stop," she sings with an affect that is both wry and daring, as bandmates join in with jaunty rockabilly rhythms. "Rose-Colored Sky" brings Tacocat's feminist sensibilities to the forefront. Though it sounds unsettlingly cheery, the song roasts the ambivalent rich who get "first prize just to participate," turning a lazy explanation of millennial malaise back on the real threat: people wholly uninterested in politics so long as the world looks good to them.

That's not to say Tacocat don't indulge in fun for fun's sake, which sometimes makes for surface-level songwriting. "Meet Me at La Palma" is, after all, a song about getting wasted on giant margaritas and dancing "the foxtrot" with someone who just broke an engagement, and there's not much more to it than that. Tacocat has released songs with similar content throughout the past decade, writing music that's consistently both sloppy and serious. Sometimes they trust the formula a little too much, and *This Mess Is a Place* can occasionally feel overly safe. But at other moments, the album radiates sneakily subversive fuck-you attitude. Most of the time, it feels like taking a joyride with four bonafide party experts egging you on as you drunk-text an ex. It's fun and messy and you might forget it completely by the next day. No regrets, though.



Photo from Bandoamp



Photo from Subpop

- 01 "Hologram"
- 02 "New World"
- 03 "Grains of Salt"
- 04 "The Joke of Life"
- 05 "Little friend"
- 06 "Rose-colored Sky"
- 07 "The Problem"
- 08 "Crystal Ball"
- 09 "Meet me at La Palma"
- 10 "Miles and Miles"

AN INTERVIEW WITH *“riot-twee”* band HEAVENLY



Photo by Alison Wonderland

Amelia Fletcher and Rob Pursey of the legendary indiepop band graced the pages of FOMO

by Quinn Moreland (Quinn's Newsletter)

I can't remember the first time I heard Heavenly but it was undoubtably love at first listen. The British indie pop band scratches the everlasting part of me that craves a little jangle, a dash of girl group wistfulness, and lyrics about cool guitar boys and yearning girls in orange corduroy dresses.

Heavenly was formed in 1989 after the dissolution of its brilliantly spunky predecessor, Talulah Gosh, and featured many of the same musicians: Amelia Fletcher (vocals/guitar), Rob Pursey (bass), Matthew Fletcher (drums; Amelia's brother), and Peter Momtchiloff (guitar). Cathy Rogers (keyboards/vocals) joined around 1992's *Le Jardin de Heavenly*. Heavenly released music on two legendary DIY labels, the UK's Sarah Records and Olympia, Washington's K. I wrote some in-depth pieces about Heavenly, Sarah, and K here and here.

Heavenly effectively ended in 1996 after Matthew died by suicide. Amelia and Rob continued to make music together as a couple and later started a label, Skep Wax. "We didn't even think about restarting Heavenly without him, it felt wrong for a long time," Amelia says of her brother over a video call. "But it's obviously been a very long time and there's this guy, Ian Button, who plays in our other bands, Swansea Sound and The Catenary Wires. He's lovely and we thought that it could work with him, he could drum in a similar way and would understand the sensitivity around the whole situation."

Later this week, Heavenly will play their first U.S. shows since 1995. The Brooklyn gigs are sold out but I believe there are still tickets to the daytime show, which also features Widowspeak and Franz Charcoal (iykyk) alongside DJ Kip Berman. Swansea Sound will then head out on mini tour with support from Jeanines. Fear not, West Coast friends—Heavenly will be swinging through in October alongside envy-inducing openers Tullycraft, All Girl Summer Fun Band, and Touch Girl Apple Blossom.

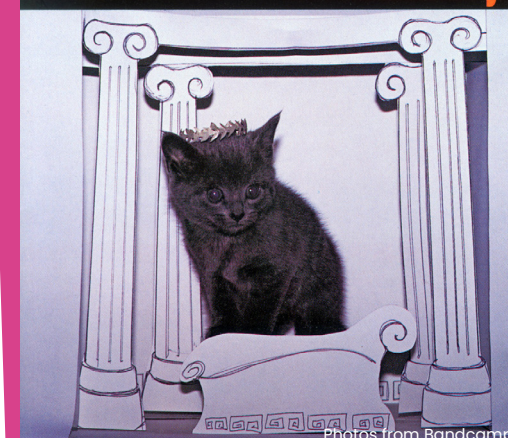
Rob and Amelia joined me to dish about riot grrrl, the changing implications of the word "twee," and finding community inside a crumbling music industry.



OPERATOR heavenly



the decline and fall of heavenly



Photos from Bandcamp

Why bring Heavenly back after all these years?

Amelia Fletcher: We have carried on doing music so we haven't felt the need to go backwards. We are always more excited about what we're doing today than what we did in the past. But we discovered that Heavenly albums and singles were selling for silly amounts on Discogs. Our friend Ian, who runs a label called Damaged Goods, asked if he could do a Heavenly singles compilation and was surprised by how well it did. So we thought, if people are that interested in Heavenly and can't get the albums, we should put them out again. Throughout the process, people started playing Heavenly on the radio and "P.U.N.K. Girl" became a bit of a TikTok viral hit.

Amelia, how has it been to revisit these songs that you wrote in your 20s? Do you hear any of your songs differently?

AF: I stopped playing guitar after Heavenly so there was the basic technical issue of not playing in 30 years! It's been really interesting to go back and realize that I actually wrote quite good songs. I remembered them as not being especially good, but they're quite smart. There aren't any lyrics that I'm too embarrassed about. It's been quite interesting to look at the development across albums with a grown-up's eye, seeing me grow from the excitable, girl groupy, love-focused first album to discovering riot grrrl to wanting to be a bit more experimental on the last album, all the while retaining a focus on pop music.

You've spoken about how visiting America and discovering riot grrrl shifted your thoughts on feminism and gave you a language to explore your anger. How did this affect your songwriting?

AF: We went over to Olympia to play some shows and discovered Bratmobile and Bikini Kill. I recently found an old interview with me about being a woman in an indie band. I'm sitting there slagging off the misogyny of the music press and being very

much in line with what riot grrrl would talk about, but what I didn't do is put it in my songs. I found riot grrrl incredibly exciting because I didn't think of myself as a feminist back in the UK. I just thought of myself as a woman amongst women who were wronged, I didn't put the F word on that. So riot grrrl taught me that there was a term for what I am. They were putting that stuff into their music and I was like, Oh, we could do that too. So there's a lyrical difference but also a musical one because we were inspired by the slightly more aggressive sound of riot grrrl, even though we never really sounded like a riot grrrl band.

Olympia has been mythologized over the years as an indie paradise, what were your first impressions of the city?

Rob Pursey: Olympia was amazing at the time because it was K and Kill Rock Stars down the road in this really small town. We had never been there before so it was very exciting but it was also amazing how easily we fit in, there was no language barrier, no culture barrier.

AF: The branding of Sarah—though they wouldn't have used that term—was what I would think of these days as indie: public transport and playing really nice songs sweetly on guitars and sharing your heart on your sleeve. It wasn't very punk. K ended up releasing quite similar music and the labels shared a lot of the same beliefs. But K had this added ethos of punk because of the close links with Dischord and I think that meant that K was able to sell its music as cooler, somehow. We were exactly the same band but we were cooler in America than in the UK.

Is there anything from that time that you think has been misconstrued or overly mythologized?

RP: I think the ambition of Sarah and what the project was trying to do politically has become clearer in retrospect. To live in Bristol and to put on pictures of buses and small trains on your record sleeves is a deliberately parochial thing. They wouldn't let bands put pictures of women on their sleeves because it was such a sexist cliché. They were doing lots of things that were really brilliant and I don't think they were totally appreciated for that. It has become mythologized and there are obsessive people who collect every Sarah single. I'm sure Matt [Haynes] and Clare [Wadd] would agree with this but not every single was brilliant, there was a varying degree of quality. So the idea that Sarah is the gateway to some shimmering, indie oasis is probably a bit exaggerated.

AF: In terms of mythologization, the only thing I would call out is that K was very much the child of both

"We decided to embrace [twee], you can't control what words mean."

Calvin Johnson and Candice Peterson. We signed to K partly because of Calvin, but it was Candice who discovered Heavenly and asked us if we wanted to be on the label. She was quiet and people didn't notice her because Calvin was such a big character. She was part of why it worked as a label, she did a lot of stuff in the background that made it successful.

What's your relationship with the word twee then and now?

RP: It was definitely an insult and we resented it. There were similar words bandied about at the time: cardigans, bedwetting, fey. There was a misogynistic undertone that if you've got a band with women in it and they don't dress like rock chicks, then they're children. But at the same time, the way some people in the scene dressed was willfully childish as if to say, the adult corporate world looks rubbish so we won't grow into it. But then twee changed and seemed to refer to slightly preppy clothes and people wearing glasses. Now it's become a sort of neutral genre term that refers to a kind of music of which we are a part,

whether we like it or not. We've decided to embrace it, you can't control what words mean. So we made some t-shirts and badges that said "riot twee" in flowery Heavenly letters.

To me, "Hearts and Crosses" is the epitome of riot twee.

AF: What I've always liked about "Hearts and Crosses" is that it's about a naive girl and starts in this very lovey, happy way before suddenly turning nasty. It was clearly about innocence destroyed. I likely wasn't thinking about this when I wrote it, but it's almost a reaction to my own older song, taking the innocence of the earlier records and adding this extra layer that suggests that I've grown up a bit.

Have you applied your own experiences on indie labels to running Skep Wax?

AF: The thing that united the bands on Sarah was that Matt and Clare really liked them. It really came across as a label of love formed by the taste of two people. Skep Wax is quite a lot of work. We're not desperate to have hits or make money off it so we're only going to release something if we absolutely love it and want people to hear it. Running a label feels like a way of helping to foster a community.

RP: One thing I did take from them and from other labels is that they are part of the ecology of an independent space. Even if you are operating

"It's been quite interesting to look at the development across albums with a grown-up's eye..."



Photo by Alison Wonderland

outside of what's called the music industry, you can create a space where music comes out and is distributed and labels are still quite an important part of that. The reason we still do music is because we never got involved in the corporate music industry so we're still quite enthusiastic and that's partly because we had labels like Sarah and K that were quite effective.

Amelia, last year you wrote a letter to Spotify CEO Daniel Ek concerning their proposal to demonetize all tracks under 1000 streams. As an economist and a musician, what about this touched a nerve for you?

AF: That specific proposal typified what we were generally upset about with Spotify but it was particularly outrageous because he talks about supporting creativity. Spotify does give a lot of money to artists and to the record industry, but they failed to recognize all the things they've cannibalized, all the physical sales that are not happening now. It feels like Payola is back, you can get on an edited playlist in return for a lower royalty rate. I was particularly upset by the language that claimed this was a strategy designed to support "real artists." How dare you? As if all these people making amazing music are not real artists.

RP: I think Spotify is the most obvious manifestation of a music industry that's become disgustingly over-centralized and corrupt and greedy. The technology of streaming is incredible, there's nothing wrong with it, per se, but the net effect of it is that the population, the consumers, have been persuaded to believe that music is pretty much free. And the reason is not because Daniel Ek is taking a pay cut, it's because all the people that make the music don't get anywhere near as much money as they used to.

A typical Swansea Sounds track satirizes the music industry. Is there anything that makes you feel optimistic?

RP: The ongoing existence of some kind of independent scene always makes me feel optimistic but it's a lot harder to be a young band. If the circling corporate vultures had their way, there would be 20 acts in the whole world and they'd all be milked to death. I think that's their happy version of the future: less creative mouths to feed and more technological ways of feeding the consumer. I suppose that doesn't sound very optimistic.

AF: It doesn't. I think there are lots of young people who really love music and that's why I don't think that AI is going to completely take over. One reason that I think they love music has to do with the character of the music and the people that make it. In the end, they care about music being made by the humans that they care about.

RP: Amelia is determined to be optimistic at all times. The level of change that's required is like when the American government broke up the railroad monopolies. In the meantime, we can carry on making little satiric noises from the corner.



HEAVENLY ANNOUNCE FIRST ALBUM IN 30 YEARS



- 01 “Scene Stealing”
- 02 “Portland Town”
- 03 “Press Return”
- 04 “Skep Wax”
- 05 “Deflicted”
- 06 “EXcuse Me”
- 07 “A Different Beat”
- 08 “Good Times”
- 09 “The Neverseen”
- 10 “She Is The One”
- 11 “That Last Day”



“Highway to Heavenly” drops February 2026

by Alex Suskind (Pitchfork)

Indie-pop quintet Heavenly will pair their already-announced 2026 tour with a new album, their first since 1996’s *Operation Heavenly*. The band—original members Amelia Fletcher, Cathy Rogers, Peter Momtchiloff, and Rob Pursey, plus new drummer Ian Button—recorded *Highway to Heavenly* with producer Toby Burroughs. It will be released on February 27 via Fletcher and Pursey’s label, Skep Wax. You can hear *Highway*’s peppy second single, “Excuse Me,” below. (Lead single “Portland Town” came out last June.)

In a statement, Heavenly promises an album filled with songs “of anger, of grief, of empathy, of love, and set themselves in opposition to the resurgence of the cold ‘masculine energy’ that is making the world a miserable, aggressive place.” Later this week, Heavenly will play their first U.S. shows since 1995. The Brooklyn gigs are sold out but I believe there are still tickets to the daytime show, which also features Widowspeak and Franz Charcoal (iykyk) alongside DJ Kip Berman. Swansea Sound will then head out on mini tour with support from Jeanines. Fear not, West Coast friends—Heavenly will be swinging through in October alongside envy-inducing openers Tullycraft, All Girl Summer Fun Band, and Touch Girl Apple Blossom.



